Puzzle I will focus on: How to open the door to progress.

The door puzzle is more so my macro-loop, as it will be used as the main goal for each level. This contains more micro-loops, some in the form of puzzles, like how to accrue crystals.

- At first, I got inspiration from a book I am writing in another class where power is gained through contracts.
    - I wanted to do similar things (use contracts) with currency and stat changes, also with a narrative driving force. The narrative is meant to show the location of invisible crystals found throughout the map. These crystal locations will follow patterns across levels that will lead to lore fragments.
    - I wanted the player to have to balance their stats while gaining enough crystals to use for attacks to get pass bosses to progress
- This was very ambitious.
    - We were taught how to make a door open dependent on an inventory.
        - I used this to replace the boss fight function for now as I don't have the time or skills to implement my full vision yet.
- At first, I only had one level where you had to pay 3 crystals to open the door. I hid the crystals in places hinted at by the npc and that was all I gave the player.
    - Patrick play-tested my game
        - said he couldn't tell exactly when he actually found a crystal.
            - Therefore, I added a popup everytime your total crystals go up, instead of only having your total in the top corner.

        - He also found ways to jump outside of the map and fall forever as well as just over the door to access the gate early
            - I extended the reset zone underneath the map and the height of the door
- I decided to introduce one thing at a time and not overwhelm the player by leaving the contract concept for level 2.
    - On level 1 the npc only introduces the idea of crystals being hidden.
- Then I started level two
    - On level two the npc pushes you to find your first contract and hints at being careful with the costs.
        - I plan on making the balancing of stats and crystals to matter a lot later on, but for now I am just forcing the player to get the contract to be able to afford opening the door. Also to introduce how exactly the contracts may function in the future.
- This took a lot of trial and error with my coding skills
    - I had to create the payment, and reward systems for both stats and crystals
        - I think right now it will only work for the 1 specific contract I have, so I need to make it so it can handle any stat increase or decrease.
    - I made sure the 1st contract has the implementation of stat changes, so the player can learn that it is possible
        - The coding for the stat changes really troubled me, but I figured it out myself and finally got it working.

Reflection:

I have less iterations of the same puzzle, and instead more like I slowly created all of the mechanics I wanted to be involved in the puzzle (even though I am still not there with only two rudimentary levels). This project was really time consuming as all of this is new to me, but once I had mechanics figured out in coding, it was a lot easier to then expand in level 2 as it was more porting over already made scenes then figuring out specific code.

The crystal finding puzzle needs play testing as I am not sure if on level 2, the pattern on location is enough yet to find the necessary second crystal.

For P4:

I want to expand this game. I want to make these 2 levels more expansive so things may be less obvious or tutorial-esque. This would lead to more exploration which would help me lean toward a more narrative experience which I wanted to do, but had to focus my limited time more on the mechanics for now. I want there to be a lot more narrative elements that I wasn't able to add yet in my timeframe. This could include hints toward what stats are important, or where easter eggs or bonuses may be.

As of right now, even though there are stat changes, they aren't really meaningful, so I want to make them more impactful as you progress into future levels.

I also want to expand on the platformer experience. I want to add hazards as well as actual level resets, as dying right now doesn't do anything but put you back on the main platform.

Finally, I want to spend the time finding assets that will fit the narrative I will attempt to implement, because as of right now, everything is placeholders.